

CHAPTER 40 — Through Glass

Thursday morning, Zoe found the room before she found the building.

Not physically.

On a floor plan.

Voss sent it at eight forty-two with six words beneath it.

THIS MAY BE WHAT P3 MEANT.

The plan belonged to an old Westmere family-assessment centre that had closed years earlier.

The building had been real.

Ordinary, even.

Supervised contact.

Family assessment.

Child interviews.

Psychology appointments.

One room on the plan was labelled:

CHILD INTERVIEW / PLAY

Beside it:

OBSERVATION 2

Between them ran a thick black line.

Zoe enlarged the scan.

The line had a note.

ONE-WAY OBSERVATION PANEL

She stopped.

Elias stood behind the other chair.

Neither spoke.

No code.

No scoring system.

No lookup.

Glass.

Zoe looked at the date on the plan.

The centre had still been operating when she entered Helen and Brian's home.

A second attachment sat beneath it.

Property-service record.

Same site.

After-hours booking.

No child name.

No recipient names.

Only a reference she already knew.

RCP-0193.

Helen and Brian.

Zoe read the booking fields.

OBSERVATION 2

AFTER-HOURS ACCESS

PRIVATE PRESENTATION

P3

There it was.

Not photographs. Not a video call. Not a file passed across a desk. A room. "They saw me."

"Yes."

"In person."

"Yes."

"And I couldn't see them."

"That is what the room arrangement indicates."

She stared at the plan. A rectangle on one side. Another on the other. A wall between them. "They stood behind glass."

"Yes."

Her chair scraped backwards. "Where is it?"

"The building?"

"Yes."

Voss had included the public address. Elias looked at her. "No."

Zoe stared.

"Why?"

"Because you asked before deciding what going there does."

"I want to see it."

"I know."

"That is a reason."

"Yes."

She waited.

He did not change his answer.

Zoe folded her arms.

"What does going there risk?"

"Unknown current use. Cameras. Former staff. Anyone paying attention to the site. You physically connecting yourself to a location

already tied to your placement.”

“What does it prove?”

“Maybe nothing.”

“Annoying.”

“Yes.”

She looked back at the floor plan.

“I still want to go.”

“I know.”

“Later.”

“Your choice.”

That helped.

A little.

* * *

The observation rooms had been built for legitimate work. That mattered. Social workers had used them. Psychologists. Assessors. The glass itself was not the crime. The shadow had not built the centre. It had changed who was watching. And why. Zoe opened only the booking metadata. The after-hours session began at five thirty. Sponsor present. Recipient household present. A child-support worker present on the visible side. The worker’s access level was ordinary. No recipient-system access. No shadow identifiers. Nothing suggesting that person knew who was behind the glass. “That worker might have thought it was a normal assessment.”

“Yes.”

“Or a play session.”

“Yes.”

“And never known I was being shown to Helen and Brian.”

“Correct.”

Zoe nodded.

Zoe let it stand.

She did not write a rule.

She already knew it.

Standing in the wrong room did not automatically make someone part of the crime.

* * *

Voss found the booking sequence.

Five seventeen.

SPONSOR ARRIVAL.

Five twenty-four.

RECIPIENT ARRIVAL.

Five thirty-one.

OBSERVATION OPEN.

Five forty.

CHILD PRESENT.

Six oh two.

CHILD EXIT.

Then nothing.

Nearly an hour later:

RECIPIENT DECISION — HOLD.

And later still, elsewhere in the record:

ACCEPT.

Zoe stared at the times.

"Twenty-two minutes."

"Yes."

"They watched me for twenty-two minutes."

"Yes."

"What was I doing?"

"Session notes may exist."

She answered before he finished.

"No."

Elias said nothing.

Maybe she had been drawing.

Maybe reading.

Maybe asking when she could go home.

Maybe eating a biscuit.

Whatever a stranger had written about those twenty-two minutes would only give the moment more detail than Zoe wanted it to have.

The adults' decision did not become more or less wrong because eight-year-old handwriting had been neat or messy.

She looked at the line again.

CHILD EXIT.

"Did I know Mac was there?"

"Unknown."

"Did I know Helen and Brian were there?"

"No evidence that you were informed."

Zoe made a face.

"Awful sentence."

“Accurate.”

“I know.”

She hated when he was right in ugly language.

Mac’s presence was strongly supported.

Helen and Brian’s presence was supported.

The room was real.

The panel was real.

P3 was real.

That settled it.

* * *

Helen remembered the room as cold.

That was the first thing.

Too much air conditioning for a building that smelled faintly of old radiators.

Brian had complained about it.

Mac told him they would not be there long.

Helen had expected photographs.

Maybe paperwork.

A discussion about the match.

Not a child.

They had already signed enough documents that turning back felt like losing something.

Not the child.

Not yet.

The possibility.

Mac led them through a corridor after most ordinary staff had gone.

A woman at reception appeared to know him.

Or perhaps she simply recognised him as someone authorised to be there.

Helen could no longer remember.

The door to the room was grey.

No sign.

Inside were three chairs facing a dark window.

Helen stopped.

“What is this?”

“Observation room,” Mac said.

Brian looked at the glass.

“You said we were discussing a match.”

“We are.”

Helen looked at Mac.

“Where are the photographs?”

“You said you wanted to know whether it felt right.”

Brian’s expression hardened.

“That isn’t what we asked.”

Mac put one hand into his coat pocket.

Relaxed.

“We can leave.”

Helen looked at Brian.

Brian looked at the door.

For a moment, leaving was simple.

Real.

Available.

No child had appeared.

Nobody had locked them in.

Mac had just told them they could go.

Brian said:

"We should."

Helen did not move.

"Helen."

"Five minutes."

"We already said this was wrong."

"I know."

"Then why are we still here?"

Helen had no answer she wanted to say aloud.

Because they had tried the lawful route.

Because the lawful route had said no.

Because there was still a bedroom upstairs with nothing in it.

Because she still woke from dreams in which her daughter was alive and spent two seconds believing them.

Because everyone told her grief would become something she could carry. Nobody had explained what to do when carrying it still felt unbearable. Mac sat down. He did not push. That was one of the things Helen had mistaken for decency. The light changed on the other side of the glass. The dark pane became a bright room. Child-sized table. Books. Pencils. A shelf of toys. A woman entered first. Then a girl. Helen forgot the cold.

* * *

Zoe came in carrying a paperback beneath one arm. The support worker said something. Zoe replied. The sound through the observation-room speaker was low. Not enough to make out every word. Zoe put the book on the table. Dark hair. The shape around the face.

Something in the mouth when she concentrated. Then she looked towards what she thought was a mirror. She pulled a face at herself. The worker laughed. Zoe smiled. Helen's hand went to her mouth. Brian saw. "No."

Helen did not look at him. "Helen."

"No what?"

"You know what."

She did. He would not say their daughter's name in front of Mac. Helen whispered: "I know."

Mac stayed seated. Brian turned on him. "You knew."

Mac's expression barely changed. "The resemblance was recorded."

"Recorded?"

"You asked for compatibility."

Brian stepped closer. "We did not ask for this."

"No."

"Then why bring us?"

"Because you have to choose."

It sounded almost honourable. That was the problem. Helen looked back through the glass. Zoe picked up a pencil. The resemblance was not perfect. Different nose. Different eyebrows. Different posture. A different child. Helen felt relief. Dangerous relief. Not a replacement. See? Different. A new child. A new chance. The resemblance only meant— Fate.

Mercy. Something meant to be. She could choose whichever word

made staying easier. Mac did not give her those words. He did not need to. Brian stood by the door. "Helen."

Zoe had started drawing. The worker leaned over the page. Zoe shook her head, changed something, then carried on. Helen moved closer to the glass. "She looks happy."

"You don't know that."

"She is laughing."

"With someone she knows."

"You don't know who that woman is."

Helen turned. "You think I don't know that?"

"I think we should leave."

"Then leave."

The words surprised both of them. Helen looked back at Zoe. A pencil rolled from the table.

Zoe bent to pick it up.

When she straightened, her hair fell across her face.

For one impossible second the years folded.

A kitchen.

A park.

A hospital corridor.

A little girl running towards Helen.

Then Zoe pushed the hair away in a movement that belonged entirely to Zoe.

Not the dead child.

Someone else.

That should have broken the spell.

Instead Helen used it as permission.

Not the same.

Not replacement.

Something new.

Something she could still call love.

* * *

The archive did not give Zoe that scene.

Not like that.

It gave her the room.

The times.

The participants.

The observation method.

The HOLD.

The ACCEPT.

The rest came from a different source.

A later recipient interview summary.

Short.

Clinical.

Enough.

APPLICANT B DESCRIBED VISUAL FAMILIARITY AS EMOTIONALLY
SIGNIFICANT AND INTERPRETED RESEMBLANCE AS
REASSURANCE RATHER THAN REPLACEMENT.

Then:

**APPLICANT A EXPRESSED CONCERN PRESENTATION MAY BE
EXPLOITING PRIOR BEREAVEMENT.**

Zoe stared at the second line.

"Brian said that."

"Yes."

"He actually said exploiting."

"Yes."

"So he knew what they might be doing."

"He identified the possibility."

Zoe looked at Elias.

He stopped there.

Good.

She looked back at the screen.

Brian had recognised it.

Helen had reframed it.

And later they both accepted. The sequence was clear.

* * *

Behind the glass, Brian finally sat down.

Only because standing had stopped changing anything.

Zoe was still drawing.

He looked at Mac.

"You score this."

Mac said nothing.

"You actually score it."

"The organisation assesses compatibility."

"Don't call it compatibility."

Helen turned from the glass.

"What did they tell you about her?"

"Only what you were cleared to receive."

"Family?"

"Origin information is restricted."

"Are they dead?"

"I didn't say that."

"Did they give her up?"

"I didn't say that either."

Brian looked at Helen.

There it was. Another door. Mac had not given them the story they wanted. No orphan. No abandoned child. No voluntary surrender. Restricted origin information. An unfinished safeguarding pathway. Exactly the kind of uncertainty they had already been warned about. Helen looked through the glass again. Zoe could not see them. That mattered. The child had no voice in the room deciding what might happen to her. Brian said: "We leave."

Helen whispered: "And then?"

"What?"

"What happens to her?"

Mac stayed quiet. Brian turned on him. "Answer."

"I don't control that."

"Another family?"

"I don't know."

"Back to her own?"

"I don't know."

"Care?"

"I don't know."

Every answer left a gap. Helen filled it. Maybe Zoe would go somewhere worse. Maybe nobody would take her. Maybe she would be moved again. Maybe Helen and Brian were not taking something. Maybe they were saving someone. Brian said: "That doesn't make us right."

Helen looked at him. "No."

The answer came quickly. She knew. Not right. Not lawful. Not clean. Still she looked back at Zoe.

"Would we love her?" Brian shut his eyes. "That is not the question." "It is to me." "No." He opened them again. "The question is whether we have the right to take her." Helen's face tightened. Take. Not adopt. Not receive. Not rescue. Take. Mac looked away. For the first time. Helen saw it. And stayed.

* * *

Zoe stood at the guesthouse window. Rain had started. Three cars in the car park. A delivery van. A man wrestling with an umbrella.

She said: "He knew."

Elias waited. "Brian understood the resemblance might be deliberate."

"Yes."

"And Helen knew there could still be family."

"Yes."

"Mac didn't tell them I was an orphan."

"No."

"Didn't say I'd been given up."

"No."

"They had a way out."

"Yes."

Zoe watched the man outside give up and close the umbrella. "And they still said yes."

"Later."

She turned. "What?"

"They did not accept in the room."

She knew that. The times.

HOLD.

Then acceptance later.

The difference mattered. They had left. They had time. They had distance. No dark glass in front of them. No Zoe smiling through a mirror. And still— Later. Yes.

* * *

Mac let them leave without an answer. "Call me when you decide." That was all. Brian drove. Helen sat beside him. For eighteen minutes neither spoke. At a red light, Brian said: "No." Helen kept looking out of the window. "We don't do it." Silence. "We already know it's wrong." "I know."

"They picked her because she looks like her."

"I know."

"That alone should tell you what this is."

Helen turned. "No."

Brian gripped the steering wheel. "Helen."

"No, I won't say no."

The light changed. A horn sounded behind them. Brian drove. At home, the empty bedroom waited upstairs. Not Zoe's yet. Nobody's. Helen made tea. Neither drank it. Brian stood at the kitchen counter. "We can reapply."

"We did."

"Later."

"How much later?"

"I don't know."

"A year?"

"Maybe."

"Two?"

"Helen."

"And then they say no again."

"Then they say no."

She looked at him. "That is easy for you."

His face changed. "No."

"You still get to call waiting the right thing."

"What do you think this is doing to me?"

Helen looked away. Across the road, a woman walked with a small child in a red coat. The child pulled towards the kerb. The woman caught her hand. Nothing dramatic. Nothing meaningful. Helen watched until they disappeared. "Life is not fair," she said.

Brian sat down. "That isn't an argument."

"I know."

"Then don't use it as one."

"I can't change what happened."

"No."

"I can't have another child."

"No."

"We did what they told us."

"Yes."

"And they said no."

"Yes."

"Someone will take that girl."

"You don't know that."

"No."

Brian waited. Helen turned back. "At least with us she would be loved."

Brian closed his eyes. There it was. The sentence that made everything after possible.

Not because it was false. Because it was true. They would love her. That truth became permission for something it could not justify. Brian said: "Love doesn't give us the right."

Helen looked down at the untouched tea. "No." Then: "But it gives her something." Brian did not answer. That was not agreement. Not yet.

* * *

The next morning Helen called Mac. Brian was in the room. She put the phone on speaker. Mac answered on the third ring. "Helen." She looked at Brian. He looked exhausted. Not surprised. "I want to proceed." Silence. Then Mac asked: "Both of you?" Helen did not answer for him. She looked at Brian. He could still say no.

He had said it in the car.

In the kitchen.

He had named the manipulation.

Named the taking.

Named the absence of right.

Brian stared at the phone.

Then nodded.

Helen closed her eyes.

"Yes," she said.

Mac said:

"I'll begin arrangements."

The call ended.

Nothing in the room changed.

No music.

No relief.

No sense that a decision had become good simply because it had become final.

* * *

Zoe read the acceptance record once.

Only once.

She did not need a spreadsheet.

Or a culpability score.

Or another notebook page explaining thresholds.

Brian had understood enough to want to leave.

Helen had understood enough to admit it was wrong. They left. They had time. Then they chose. Zoe closed the file. For a while neither she nor Elias spoke. Finally she said: "They could love me and still not have the right."

"Yes."

She looked at him. "Not own me."

"No."

That word was simpler. Better. They had raised her. They had loved her. They had also chosen the beginning. All three things could exist. Zoe hated that. It remained true anyway.

* * *

At eleven twenty, Zoe asked to go to the building again. This time Elias did not say no.

He asked:

"What does going there do?"

"I don't know."

"Risk?"

"Some."

"Need?"

"Yes."

He watched her.

She continued.

"I'm not going to search it. I'm not going inside if it's occupied. I don't need evidence. I want to see where it happened."

Elias nodded.

"Then we look."

No victory.

No permission.

Information.

Choice.

They changed vehicles once before the final approach.

The old centre stood behind a low brick wall and a line of wet trees.

The council had sold it years earlier.

Part of the building now held offices.

Another section looked empty.

A sign near the gate advertised units to let.

Nothing about it looked like a place that should live inside Zoe's head.

They parked two streets away. Walked. Eight minutes. That was all. Zoe did not cross the fence. Did not touch the building. Did not photograph the entrance. She stood opposite it and looked at a row of rectangular windows. Somewhere behind one of them had been the room. She could not tell which. Strangely, that helped. The place did not deserve precision. Helen had once told Zoe: I loved you from the first moment I saw you. Zoe had always imagined a normal first meeting. A doorway. A social worker. Some nervous adult smile. Not this. A child behind glass. A family deciding whether she felt right. Zoe looked at the building. The sentence formed.

You saw me through glass. She did not say it aloud. Not to Elias. Not to Helen. It belonged to Zoe until she decided otherwise. A delivery van passed. The driver did not look at them. Someone opened a window in

the office section. A phone rang faintly inside. Ordinary place. Ordinary morning. Zoe turned away. "That's enough." They walked back to the car.

* * *

On the drive away, Zoe opened the notebook. Not the archive. The notebook. She looked at a blank page. Then closed it again. Elias glanced across. "Nothing?" "I know what I think."

"That can happen without writing it."

"Apparently."

She watched wet hedges slide past. Then: "I want what Helen and Brian did to be known." Elias said nothing.

"I want Mac's part known."

Nothing. "The order. The match. The payments. All of it."

"Yes."

She looked out of the window. "But I'm not putting every kid in that drive online because I'm angry."

"No."

"Not their names."

"No."

"Not where they live."

"No."

"Not their families if they did nothing."

"No."

She looked at him. "You can stop saying no now."

"I was agreeing."

"Same word."

"Different use."

She sighed.

The point remained.

Her anger did not create ownership either.

Not over another child's history.

Not over somebody else's placement.

Not over a family that had done nothing wrong.

What Helen and Brian had chosen belonged in the evidence.

What an unrelated child had survived did not become Zoe's weapon.

That line mattered more now because revenge would have been easier.

* * *

By early afternoon, the personal picture was finally complete enough to hurt in one piece.

Why Helen and Brian?

Because grief and failed adoption made them vulnerable.

Why Zoe?

Because the system believed familiarity would turn vulnerability into attachment.

Why ninety-seven?

Because she fitted the household and resembled the daughter they had lost.

Why had the system come back for her five years later?

Because an outside enquiry had touched the placement and the people behind it needed control before the old lie became visible.

Why had everything after that become worse?

Because every attempt to contain the first wrong had created another current problem.

None of those answers made Zoe feel better.

They did something else.

They stopped the questions moving.

For weeks, each answer had opened another door.

This one closed something.

Not the whole story.

Her part of the old one.

* * *

At two forty-seven, Voss's dormant handset lit.

Vale saw it first.

Unknown number.

One message.

No greeting.

No name.

Tell Zoe I did not give them the second route.

Vale stopped breathing for a second.

Voss read it.

Then another arrived.

They made me give the first one.

Vale looked at him.

"Jackie."

"Likely."

"Don't."

"I said likely."

A third message appeared. My brother and sisters are alive.

Vale stared.

"Oh, God."

Voss did not reply.

He photographed the screen.

No names.

No response to the unknown number.

Then he sent the image through the one-use route.

Powered the handset down.

Vale looked at him.

"Do we tell her now?"

"Yes."

No argument.

* * *

Elias received the image while driving.

He did not hand the phone to Zoe immediately.

He pulled into the car park behind a farm shop.

Beige estate.

Rain beginning again.

Engine off.

Then he passed her the screen.

Zoe read the first message.

Tell Zoe I did not give them the second route.

Her hand tightened around the phone.

Second.

They made me give the first one.

Third. My brother and sisters are alive.

For several seconds she did not move.

The world outside the windscreen remained stupidly normal.

Shopping trolleys.

A woman loading potatoes into a boot.

A handwritten sign advertising eggs.

Jackie.

Alive.

Maybe.

Likely.

Her siblings alive.

The route.

The first route forced from her.

The later route not.

Everything Zoe had believed in pieces shifted again.

Elias said:

“Likely Jackie.”

Zoe nodded. She did not fight the word. Not now. Her hands had started shaking. “She’s alive.”

“Likely.”

Zoe closed her eyes once. Opened them. The urge arrived immediately. Find the number. Find the house. Find Cain. Go. Elias watched her. He did not say what they should do. That mattered. “What do you need?”

Zoe looked again at the three messages. The glass. Helen. Brian. Mac.

All of it dropped away.

One person remained.

“Jackie.”